

Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 21



CHAPTER 21



"SEALING IS SAFER"

Stunned with the news, Nat went to see Mary and Lois. Lois wept, but Mary was beyond tears. She only said, over and over, "I hate the sea, Nat. I hate it. *I hate it.*"

When she asked him what he was going to do now, he only said he hadn't decided. It was no time to tell Mary he was going to write a book on navigation. It was no time to talk to anyone in Salem about book sailing — not right now.

Mrs. Boardman was glad to see him. Polly was not there. Mrs. Boardman hoped she would come for a visit soon. She missed Polly.

In his bedroom-study, Nat began to work on his tables, checking and rechecking every figure. When he had worked so long that the numbers danced in front of his eyes, he switched to other parts of the book. Over and over again he wrote each paragraph, each sentence, to explain navigation to the man before the mast.

As he worked, he remembered the men he had trained: Keeler — Johnny — Owens — Lem . . . When he thought of Lem he stopped working and pounded his fist on the

desk in helpless rage. Then he thought of Hab and William, and memories drove him back to his work until the pain was numb again.

Mrs. Boardman worried about him. "Nat, dear, you should get more rest!"

"I'll rest when the book is done."

Mrs. Boardman had no answer when he spoke of the book. She only sighed and shook her head. Polly came from Danvers to see her Aunt Mary. Mrs. Boardman said, "Thank goodness you've come! Now someone will help me scold Nat!"

“What’s he doing?”

“Working too hard. You’d think he was writing a whole cyclopaedia instead of just one book.”

Polly’s eyes widened. “A book? What about?”

Nat was getting edgy about the book. “Navigation!” he snapped. “Is there any reason why not?”

Mrs. Boardman gasped, but Polly seemed undisturbed. “About time you did one. Come on and tell me about it.”

They talked until supper, and after.

The next day at dinner Mrs. Boardman said, “Nat, you worked till all hours last night.”

"It was going well," Nat said, "after talking to Polly. I suppose it's the long line of sea captains in her blood."

Polly nodded. "Cut my teeth on a marline-spike," she declared, "and tied knots instead of playing with dolls, I did."

Mrs. Boardman looked reproachful. "Polly! You're not going to be a bit of help to me! I tell you, he's working too hard."

Polly stopped smiling. "Aunt Mary, think of it this way; if a ship was aground off Salem Harbor — say on Rising States Ledge — or the Haste — every able-bodied man in Salem would be out there trying to save the crew, wouldn't he?"

“Of course!”

“And the women wouldn’t try to stop them, would they? No matter how long and hard they worked? No matter if they were risking their lives?”

“No-o-o-o,” Mrs. Boardman admitted, “when a ship is in danger, men do everything they can.”

“Well, every ship is in danger, every time it sails,” Polly said. “But the more men know about navigation, the safer our ships will be, won’t they? Nat isn’t working to save just one ship. He’s working to make every ship safer every time it goes to sea. Every ship in America!” Polly was really warming to her idea. “Every ship in the world!”

“Polly, dear!” Mrs. Boardman smiled. “You don’t expect other countries to pay attention to an American book, do you?”

“Why not?” Polly wanted to know. “Nat’s the best teacher of navigation in the world. And that isn’t my say-so. It’s what Father says. He’s had men who’ve sailed with Nat. He said, ‘When it comes to teaching any fool navigation, Nat Bowditch is the . . .’” She stopped and rolled her eyes at her aunt. “Well, you know how Father talks. But what he meant was that Nat can teach navigation.”

Mrs. Boardman shook her head and looked at Nat's plate. "He isn't eating a thing."

Polly looked at his plate, too. "If you don't want any dessert" — she nodded toward the door — "then get along back to work."

Nat chuckled, excused himself, and raced up the stairs. The rest of that day, and that night, the work went faster than it ever had.

He had no idea what time it was when someone tapped on his door. It was Polly with a tray of cookies and milk. "I'm not a bit hungry," he declared.

“Then don’t eat it.” She set the tray on his desk.
“Happy figuring! Good night!” And she was gone.

Nat went on working. After a while something bothered him. His hand was pawing at the empty tray, fishing for another cooky. “Now when did I . . .” He shook his head. “That Polly!”

After that, he found himself listening for her step. When he heard her coming, he would lay aside his work, lean back, and twiddle his thumbs. “Sit down a while, Polly. I’m just at a stopping place.”

One night two weeks later, Polly set the tray down and turned to the door. "I'm busy tonight," she said. "And tomorrow night, you'll have to raid the galley for your own lunch."

Nat felt a quick stab of disappointment. How silly, he told himself. He followed her to the hall. "You're going to a party?" He smiled. "Have a good time."

"I'm going home," Polly said. "I just came for a little visit. Aunt Mary gets lonesome, and I — "

“But — but — you can’t go, Polly! What would I do without you? To talk to? To laugh with? You can’t ever leave me, Polly! You — ” And she was in his arms. “I love you, Polly.”

“I’ve always loved you,” she whispered. “Ever since I can remember.”

“Polly, will you . . .” He stopped. They stared at each other. He knew they were thinking of the same thing.

Polly said it. “But what would Aunt Mary say? How would she feel about — ”

A door opened, and Polly's Aunt Mary said, "She's happy for both of you. That's how she feels about it." She kissed them. "I'm going to ask you to do just one thing for me. Live here — with me. You're like my own children. I'd miss you so."

In late October, when the leaves were a riot of red and gold, they were married.

Mrs. Boardman said, "Nat, I hope you're not going to take that book with you on your honeymoon!"

Nat promised he wouldn't even think about the book.

They honeymooned in Danvers. Nat saw again the little house with two rooms where he had lived. One evening they walked at twilight and scuffed autumn leaves. The new moon rose. Nat remembered the night, so long ago, when he had waited for Hab to go to sleep so he could work his good-luck spell.

If I still believed in spells . . . he thought.

Polly paused and looked up at the moon. "Give me some silver to jingle, Nat. Not that the book will need a good-luck spell." She jingled the silver solemnly. For a moment she was silent. "Nat, why don't we take the rest of our honeymoon after the book comes out?"

"Polly! You don't mean you want to go back to Salem now, and have me start working on the book?"

"That's exactly what I mean! Maybe you can forget about it, but I can't!"

Soon Nat was at work again — longer hours than ever. One night, when they had planned to go to a party, Nat looked up, all at once, remembering. It was midnight.

He dashed to their bedroom. Polly was reading. He was so ashamed of himself that he snapped at Polly.

“The party! Why didn’t you remind me?”

Polly looked unconcerned. “You know, I had the most awful headache.”

Nat snorted. “You never had a headache in your life!”

“I know. That’s why this one was so awful.”

“You’re fibbing and you know it!”

Polly grinned. “You can’t prove a thing.”

Nat began laughing.

“I’m becoming a terrible creature,” Polly said. “Sometimes when people come to call, I say you’re asleep.”

One day, though, she did interrupt him for callers. "It's Father and Captain Prince! They're all on fire about something! I can tell."

The "something" was the idea of investing — the three of them — in a sealing ship. "There's a fortune to be made in a sealer," Captain Ingersoll declared, "and there's not the risk that there is in whaling. None of that staying out two, three, and four years, either. You know where the rookeries of the seals are and you know the season they gather there. You go — you round up the the young bulls — drive them off to the killing grounds and bang them over the head. And that is that."

"Almost as much profit as there is in the pepper

trade," Captain Prince said. "And none of the danger. No Malay gangs climbing up your cable and ripping your . . . uh . . . well . . . knifing you with those wavy daggers."

Captain Ingersoll walked the floor and smiled. "We've got our eye on a trim little craft — the *John*. We can put up two thirds of what it will take to outfit her. How about it, Nat? Do you want to put up the other third?"

"Right!" They shook hands on it.

Polly and Nat were at the wharf when the *John* sailed. Nat thought back over the years — the shilling he'd invested in Tom Perry's expectations — the hundred and

thirty-five dollars he had risked in his first venture on the *Henry*. He'd come along a bit since then — with one-third interest in a sealer. "Polly," he said, "you've married a capitalist!"

"And a navigator," she said.

Nat pretended to groan. "That's a hint to get back to work. Slave driver!"

In the spring Nat finished the book. Before he presented the manuscript to Mr. Blunt, he took it to the East India Marine Society of Salem. Those were the men to judge the book — sailing masters, every one of them — who'd doubled the Cape or the Horn. They were the

men who had spread the name of Salem so far and wide that natives of some distant islands thought Salem was a country — near the United States — and probably bigger. Yes, they were the men to sit in judgment on the book.

It was May 6 when the committee met to consider the book. On May 10, there was still no word.

“What *are* they doing, Nat?” Polly asked.

“Reading it — I hope.”

Two more days crawled by; then, on May 13, their judgment came. Polly read the page-long letter, bristling with words like *amplitude*, *parallax*, and *refraction*.

“Why don’t they just say it’s wonderful?”

Nat smiled. “They say it’s *the most correct and ample* book on navigation in existence. From the East India Marine Society, that’s praise! It’s worth a ten-gun salute from any other men. Tomorrow, the manuscript goes to Mr. Blunt.”

Polly smiled. “Well, that’s done!”

“It’s just begun. Now I start proofreading.”

“Won’t Mr. Blunt do that?”

“No one will proofread that book but me!”

“How long will it take you? A month?”

Nat chuckled and shook his head. "Bless you, Polly, I'll be lucky if it only takes a year."

When Nat was not busy with checking on the book, he did have time to enjoy his friends in Salem. He had long talks with Dr. Holyoke. What an amazing man he was! In 1799 he had celebrated fifty years of practice in Salem, and he declared he felt he could keep on for fifty more.

One evening he visited with Nat and Polly, and the talk turned to astronomy and Cadiz. "Like to see that observatory again, Nat?" he asked.

“Yes, but I probably won’t.”

Polly said, “He’s swallowed the anchor. He’s a capitalist now.”

Dr. Holyoke chuckled and then scowled when a knock came on the door. “Might as well answer it for you, Polly. It’ll be someone for me. A doctor never spends a whole evening without an interruption. He — ”

But it was someone to see Nat — Zack Selby. Zack was out of breath with running; his pig eyes were gloating.

He could not wait to tell his news. The *John* had been stove in. The crew had been rescued by another boat, and just brought back to Salem. "But you fellows lost your shirts," Zack gloated, "when the *John* went down!"

Dr. Holyoke's eyes blazed; he doubled his fists.

Polly squeezed Nat's hand. "You're sure all the men are safe? Thank God for that!"

Zack sidled to the door before he fired his parting shot. "Thanks to God, maybe. No thanks to *books*!" And he scuttled out.